

CHAPTER 1

I SPY

'Whoever is tapping our phones should have some fun.'

They came early in the afternoon. Jogesh, the inspector of Vanchiyoor police station, Trivandrum, Thambidurga Dutt, the sub-inspector, and the two constables were cordial.

'Sir, the DIG wants to talk to you,' said Jogesh.

'Am I under arrest?' I asked.

'No, sir' the inspector said, 'The DIG wants to talk to you.'

I put on a shirt and trousers and walked out with them to the waiting police jeep.

'Should I take the backseat or should I sit in the front?' I asked.

In Kerala, criminals are dumped between the back seats that constables occupy to land blows on the back of the accused. Usually the police inspector or the sub-inspector sat in the front seat. Jogesh was considerate. He ushered me to the front seat.

This arrest, as it turned out, was not totally unexpected. The date was 30 November 1994.

More than a month earlier, on 20 October to be precise, a Maldivian woman named Mariam Rasheeda was arrested on charges of overstaying in Trivandrum. In the subsequent days, Malayalam newspapers had reported her alleged role as a spy and a conduit in carting away India's rocket secrets to Pakistan by using some contacts in Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO). On 13 November, the local police arrested another Maldivian